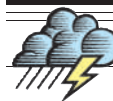


The Washington Post

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T-storm 77/66 • Tomorrow: Rain, t-storm 79/61 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, MAY 29, 2025 • \$4

CIA ramps up its hunt for human intelligence

Rebuilding spy ranks poses tall order in age of ubiquitous surveillance

BY WARREN P. STROBEL
AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

The CIA earlier this month unveiled a new gambit to persuade disgruntled Chinese officials to spy for the United States: a pair of Hollywood-quality videos that play on divisions within President Xi Jinping's government and offer instructions on how to anonymously contact the CIA.

One video highlights the vast wealth disparities between working-class Chinese and Communist Party elites; another depicts how top party officials suddenly disappear — a real-life occurrence in Xi's anti-corruption purges. The videos, narrated in Mandarin and posted on social media, are part of a new CIA strategy for recruiting potential foreign agents from afar.

It's a strategy that has already borne some fruit in Russia, CIA officials say. The spy agency in 2023 released similar videos aimed at recruiting Russians disaffected by the Ukraine war. Intelligence officials said that people there had contacted the CIA as a result, but they declined to provide details. CIA officials say they have evidence their messages aimed at China are being viewed there, despite heavy internet censorship.

But the videos also highlight a problem: The CIA needs more spies. The traditional tactics of human espionage, increasingly, are not working, current and former U.S. intelligence officials say.

The CIA's success in recruiting foreigners to share vital secrets with the United States has declined sharply in recent years, the officials said. Recruitment of new agents has dropped by double-digit percentages since 2019, one former official said. The precise numbers are highly classified.

"We all know that the human intelligence collection isn't where it needs to be," CIA Director John Ratcliffe said at his Senate confirmation hearing in January.

SEE INTELLIGENCE ON A5



ABDEL KAREEM HANA/AP

People carry bags of flour after storming a U.N. World Food Program warehouse in the central Gaza Strip on Wednesday.

U.N. condemns new Gaza aid plan

BY LOUISA LOVELUCK,
ABBIE CHEESEMAN
AND CATE BROWN

JERUSALEM — A U.S.- and Israeli-backed process for distributing aid in the Gaza Strip faced growing criticism Wednesday after scores of Palestinians were wounded across two days of deliveries. Fearful, desperate crowds thronged locations where food was being handed out, underscoring the scale of the hunger crisis in the besieged and shattered enclave.

Scores of Palestinians shot in early days of U.S.-backed deliveries

U.N. officials said that as many as 50 people appeared to have been shot and injured near the private aid distribution site in the southern city of Rafah's Tel al-Sultan neighborhood Tuesday, and that crowds had overrun a World Food Program

distribution site near Deir al-Balah in central Gaza on Wednesday, sacking it for individual bags of flour, before themselves being attacked by armed looters.

"Initial reports indicate two people died and several were injured in the tragic incident," WFP said in a statement. A health official at the nearby al-Aqsa Martyrs Hospital, Eyad Amawi, said later that three people had been killed.

"Humanitarian needs have spiraled out of control after 80

days of complete blockade of all food assistance and other aid into Gaza," WFP said.

Israel has barred nearly all food and medical supplies from entering Gaza since March 2, leaving parts of the population on the brink of starvation. The newly launched aid program is run by the Gaza Humanitarian Foundation, a controversial private organization that began distributing food in Gaza this week. The mechanism is Israeli-approved, secured by private

SEE GAZA ON A12

Decades-old roads equity program unconstitutional, DOJ argues

BY JULIAN MARK

The Trump administration moved Wednesday to dismantle one of the federal government's largest and longest-standing affirmative action programs, siding with two White-owned contracting businesses that challenged its constitutionality.

In a motion filed in the U.S. District Court for the Eastern Dis-

trict of Kentucky, the Justice Department said that a Transportation Department program that has carved out an estimated \$37 billion for minority- and women-owned businesses violates the equal protection clause of the Constitution. If a judge approves the proposed settlement, the Disadvantaged Business Enterprise Program (DBE) will be prohibited from awarding contracts based on

race and sex, effectively ending its founding mission.

"Over the past five decades, the federal government imposed a policy of race discrimination in the roadbuilding industry," said Dan Lennington, deputy counsel at the Wisconsin Institute for Law & Liberty, the conservative non-profit representing the plaintiffs. "Thousands of workers and small businesses have been victimized,

and hundreds of billions have been spent, distorting the market and inflating construction costs for the taxpayers. That ends now."

The settlement is still subject to challenge by a coalition of businesses that intervened in the case after President Donald Trump took office, arguing that the program is essential to removing entrenched barriers that minorities

SEE SETTLEMENT ON A2

Ruling freezes Trump's tariffs

TRADE COURT SAYS HE EXCEEDED POWER

'Emergency' argument is rejected; appeal is certain

BY DAVID J. LYNCH
AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

A specialized federal court in New York on Wednesday ruled that most of President Donald Trump's tariffs — including those on Chinese goods — are illegal, upending negotiations with more than a dozen nations and creating fresh uncertainty for countless American businesses that depend upon foreign suppliers.

The decision by the little-known Court of International Trade neutered the president's signature trade initiative: the comprehensive flurry of import taxes he announced on April 2 under the banner of "Liberation Day."

Those tariffs sent the value of U.S. stocks, bonds and the dollar into sharp decline, causing global investors to rethink their habitual faith in the United States and raising questions about the U.S. economic outlook.

The trade court's ruling that Trump exceeded his authority in imposing tariffs on all imported goods brought an immediate, albeit perhaps temporary, halt to his signature trade war policy.

"The challenged Tariff Orders will be vacated and their operation permanently enjoined," a three-judge panel ruled.

Futures contracts on the S&P 500 stock index jumped 1.4 percent on the news. But a few hours later, the Justice Department said in a federal court filing that it will appeal.

The trade court's decision in a pair of lawsuits filed last month against the government applies to the 10 percent tariffs Trump imposed on all foreign products as well as the much higher levies applied to goods from several dozen nations. The president invoked a 1977 law that granted him emergency powers over the economy, the International Emergency Eco-

SEE TARIFFS ON A8

Ukraine's lost war dogs are getting a leg up

Adopting animals that were abandoned on battlefields has become a national duty

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY,
KOSTIANTYN KHODOV
AND SERHIY MORGUNOV

KYIV — Soon after Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022, Kyiv's top diplomat made a very personal and little-known policy decision: He encouraged Ukraine's Foreign Ministry staff to bring their dogs to work.

Dmytro Kuleba's rule meant employees didn't have to leave their terrified dogs at home during missile and drone attacks.

And it meant Kuleba's new rescue, a gray French bulldog named Marik, scooped from the wreckage of the besieged Ukrainian port city of Mariupol, would spend the next couple of years overhearing foreign policy discussions as he waddled around the office.

Such an arrangement might seem unusual for a foreign minister — but not in wartime Ukraine. Russia's invasion has made the

security of pets a national priority. Families in front-line towns often flee Russian shelling with multiple pets in tow, and soldiers feed and care for those left behind. Volunteers then risk their lives to evacuate them to safer cities, where they are often adopted into Ukrainian families or sent abroad.

The lengths Ukrainian troops and volunteers have gone to rescue vulnerable dogs has spurred a massive cultural shift, transforming Ukraine — once criticized for its treatment of animals — into an extraordinarily dog-friendly country. Gone are stuffy old rules banning pets from many places. Kuleba resigned in 2024, but the Foreign Ministry confirmed that his dog policy remains in place.

Dogs are also now welcome inside most restaurants, cafes, beauty

SEE DOGS ON A10

Peace talks: Ukraine and Russia to meet in Istanbul next week. **A12**



SERHIY MORGUNOV/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Dmytro Kustov with his pup, Kari. The war with Russia has softened Ukrainians' attitudes toward dogs.

Delay to Air Force One deal as Qatar probes legal liability

Despite U.S. claims, the luxury jetliner's transfer has not been finalized

BY JOHN HUDSON,
NATALIE ALLISON,
DAN LAMOTHE
AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

Despite claims by the Defense Department to the contrary, legal teams representing the U.S. and Qatari governments have not finalized an agreement for transferring the luxury Boeing 747-8 jetliner that President Donald Trump wants for Air Force One amid outstanding requests by Qatar for Washington to clarify the transaction's terms, said officials familiar with the matter.

Qatar is insisting that a memorandum of understanding between Washington and Doha specify that the aircraft's transfer was initiated by the Trump administration and that Qatar is not

responsible for any future transfers of the plane's ownership, these people said.

The delay reflects lingering concerns about legal liability stemming from the White House maneuver to transform what was originally a sale between two countries into a "gift" that Trump continues to tout as a major deliverable from his recent trip to the Middle East.

"[I] got a beautiful big magnificent free airplane for the United States Air Force," Trump told reporters in the Oval Office on Wednesday. "Very proud of that."

The outstanding legal work is not expected to scuttle the plane deal, the officials said, but the clarifications are likely to invite further scrutiny of the administration's claims about how the deal originated.

Trump initially said it was Qatar that reached out and offered him the luxury jet free of charge.

SEE PLANE ON A8

Inspectors general: Several picks have partisan backgrounds. **A4**

IN THE NEWS

Sinking cities Twenty-eight of the United States' most populous cities are facing land subsidence, a phenomenon that threatens critical infrastructure. **A18**

To Bee or not to Bee Spelling coach Scott Remer has 27 students competing in the 2025 national Scripps competition. **B1**

THE NATION **Chimney Rock**, N.C., hit by Hurricane Helene, is still rebuilding and asking questions. **A3**
New student visas were paused ahead of tougher vetting of applicants' social media. **A6**

THE WORLD **A 2-year-old** American girl was "deported" to Brazil with her undocumented parents. **A9**
In France, a former doctor got a 20-year sentence for sexually abusing 299 people. **A12**

THE ECONOMY **A German court** dismissed a lawsuit against an energy giant but left open the possibility for other polluters to be held liable for climate change. **A13**
Data suggests the U.S. crypto reserves will hold more than \$21 billion in cryptocurrency. **A14**

THE REGION **D.C. Mayor** Muriel E. Bowser's 2026 budget proposal would scale back health care for immigrants and low-income adults. **B1**
The D.C. Streetcar, which began operating in 2016 after a decade of planning, will be replaced. **B1**

STYLE **Voice of America** employees who are on paid leave are bracing for expected terminations of most, if not all, positions. **C1**
LOCAL LIVING **Esther the Wonder Pig's** dads pick up the pieces after her death — and a messy breakup.

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